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Undertale and the Weight of Choice

Moral Accountability in Toby Fox's Independent RPG

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PART ONE

History

The Lineage of Moral Accounting in the RPG

The role-playing game has always been, at least nominally, a genre about identity. The player assumes a role, acquires power, and navigates a world that responds to their presence. However, for most of the genre's early history, this responsiveness was largely mechanical. The world reacted to a player's combat power, not their moral character, as enemies fell, experience points accumulated, and the player's "level" rose as a straightforward index of competence. The question of whether violence against these opponents was ethically meaningful rarely arose, because the genre's conventions relegated it irrelevant. As game scholars have observed, "role-playing games trivialise the unknown, the mythical and the monstrous and turn it into neat tables of cookie cutter monsters; into pests that need to be cleared" (qtd. in Elvery 480).

The first major disruption to this pattern came in 1985, when Richard Garriott released *Ultima IV: Quest of the Avatar*. Because the first three *Ultima* games were published by other companies, player letters never reached Garriott directly. But once *Ultima III* appeared under his own label, he was confronted for the first time by how fans played his games. Players, as it turned out, had been murdering NPCs, looting towns, and exploiting every available shortcut to maximize their power (Pearson). As Garriott reflected in a later interview, "I realized that in all three *Ultimas*, I had created games in which the best way to min-max the game was to be un-virtuous" (qtd. in Pearson). For *Ultima IV*, he reversed the entire premise of the genre. Instead of charging the player with defeating an antagonist, the game asked them to embody honesty, compassion, valour, justice, sacrifice, honour, spirituality, and humility across all their in-game decisions. Any moral dilemmas were designed to give players the opportunity to reap temporary rewards for amoral behaviour, only to realize later that they have been penalized.

Ultima IV did not merely add a moral layer on top of standard RPG mechanics; it restructured the game entirely around ethical behaviour. Garriott's central concern was what he described as the "puppeteer" problem of earlier RPGs: "in most of these games you are the puppeteer running this puppet around the world. If this puppet is doing bad things, it's not you, it's the puppet" (qtd. in Zagal 115). *Ultima IV* was designed to close that gap, creating a character who was meant to be "the essence of you as an individual"

rather than a neutral avatar for optimization. It established, for the first time in the medium, a precedent for what game studies scholar José Zagal has described as “ethical reflection” in video games—that is, the capacity of a game’s mechanics, narrative, and interface working together to make the player feel personally invested and responsible for the decisions made in the game (Zagal 110).

The decades following *Ultima IV* saw this principle absorbed and, in many ways, diluted by mainstream RPG design. Games like the *Fable* series (2004–2010) and *Mass Effect* (2007) adopted visible moral “meters” that reduced ethical decision-making to a binary axis (good versus evil) in which virtue was rewarded with cosmetic upgrades and vice with darker colour palettes. These systems were responsive but shallow: a player who chose “Paragon” dialogue options in *Mass Effect* was simply asked to maximize a visible stat, not to question what paragon behaviour meant. The moral dimension of such games was ultimately another resource to be optimized.

Meanwhile, an alternative tradition ran alongside the mainstream. Japanese RPGs—particularly the *Shin Megami Tensei* series, which allowed players to negotiate with and recruit demon enemies—were developing mechanics that challenged the genre’s presumption that violence was the natural mode of interaction. The *Mother* series (known as *EarthBound* in Western markets) pushed this further by foregrounding the emotional texture of its characters and world in ways that made combat feel genuinely costly. These were the games that would most directly influence a young Toby Fox.

The Making of Undertale

Undertale did not surface from a major studio with a design team and a budget. It came into being by a twenty-three-year-old musician and hobbyist programmer working almost entirely alone. Toby Fox had spent his adolescence on Starmen.net, an *EarthBound*-centred fan forum, under the username “Radiation,” contributing ROM hacks and music and eventually managing a subsection of the site dedicated to PK Hack, a tool for modifying the game. His earliest game development experience predated even this, as he and his three brothers often used RPG Maker 2000 to make role-playing games, though few were ever completed (Wikipedia, “Toby Fox”). He began serious development on *Undertale* in January 2013, after, according to his own account, accidentally reading a Wikipedia article about programming arrays and deciding to build a battle system.

Fox wanted to develop a role-playing game that was different from the traditional design, which he often found “boring to play.” He set out to develop a game with “interesting characters,” and one that “utilizes the medium as a storytelling device... instead of having the story and gameplay abstractions be completely separate” (qtd. in Han-Tani). To fund development, Fox launched a Kickstarter campaign with a modest goal of \$5,000. The computer game, which would be almost entirely built, developed, and scored by Fox himself, had a relatively simple premise—a child falls through a hole in a cave and arrives in a fantastical underground world where monsters have been forced to reside after an epic battle with the human race. The campaign was launched on June 25, 2013, with a goal of US\$5,000. It ended on July 25, 2013, with US\$51,124 raised by 2,398 people. Fox had raised ten times his goal in thirty days.

The game that flourished from this campaign, released on September 15, 2015, arrived at a particular cultural moment. By the mid-2010s, the games industry had established a robust space for games built by indie developers: *Fez* (2012), *Papers, Please* (2013), *Spelunky* (2012), and *Hotline Miami* (2012) had each demonstrated that a single author’s vision, when executed with sufficient craft and conceptual clarity, could achieve commercial success and serious critical attention. The term “auteur game” was entering the critical vocabulary. *Undertale* fit this moment perfectly. It was, in every measurable sense, the product of one person’s sustained and idiosyncratic imagination.

Undertale’s reception was immediate and overwhelming. Within months of its release, it had become a cultural phenomenon, generating fan communities, critical analyses, and a volume of player discourse unusual for any game and especially so for a modestly budgeted indie title with 16-bit-era graphics. As of writing, the game has already sold over six million Steam units, gaining roughly \$30 million in gross revenue, proving its powerhouse status. It earned nominations for Game of the Year, Best Narrative, and Excellence in Design at multiple industry awards ceremonies, competing alongside major studio releases with budgets many orders of magnitude larger. Its critical reception consistently emphasized what was unprecedented about it: the philosophical depth and formal rigor with which Fox had integrated ethics into every layer of the game’s design.

PART TWO

Analysis

The ACT/MERCY System and the Problem of Choice

Every combat encounter in *Undertale* presents the player with four options on the bottom of their screen: FIGHT, ACT, ITEM, and MERCY. The structure is visually and mechanically familiar to anyone who has played a Japanese RPG, as it recalls the menu systems of *Dragon Quest*, *Final Fantasy*, and *Pokémon*. What is radically different, though, is what happens when the player does not choose FIGHT.



The ACT menu opens a list of context-specific interactions with the enemy: talking, threatening, complimenting, performing tricks, asking questions. These interactions do not deal damage. They do not reduce the enemy's health or build toward a victory condition in any conventional sense. What they do, incrementally, is alter the enemy's emotional state—something the player can track through a changing flavour text readout beneath the enemy's sprite. When the enemy has been sufficiently affected, the MERCY button activates, allowing the player to spare them. The encounter ends without violence, without experience points, and without the satisfactions the genre has trained players to expect.

Frederic Seraphine, in his analysis of *Undertale*'s ethics at the Digital Games Research Association (DiGRA) conference, identifies the procedural asymmetry between the FIGHT and ACT systems as the game's primary rhetorical instrument. Drawing on Ian Bogost's concept of "procedural rhetoric"—the capacity of computational processes to make persuasive arguments through the rules they encode—Seraphine argues that the mechanical richness of ACT compared to the mechanical poverty of FIGHT is itself a moral argument (Seraphine 4). While it is probably not what leads players to consciously realize the moral message of the game, there is an imbalance between the fighting system and the acting system in *Undertale*. This blatant imbalance illustrates the procedural rhetoric of the game at work. While only the fight mechanics allow raising the player's EXP and LV, the game is nonetheless putting many efforts into providing a rewarding, variable experience with the act mechanics.



The FIGHT mechanic is intentionally flat. When the FIGHT button is pressed, an elliptical target appears and the player must press [Z]/[ENTER] when a bar crosses the centre. This mini game never changes. It does not become more complex or expressive. It is,

by design, the most mechanically inert option available. The ACT system, by contrast, is bottomless: each of the game's dozens of enemies has a unique set of interactions, a unique emotional profile, and a unique condition for mercy. To spare a monster requires attention, curiosity, and a willingness to understand them on their own terms. To kill one requires almost nothing.

Gabriel Elvery, writing in *Games and Culture*, extends this analysis by examining how the ACT/MERCY system reconfigures the role of monsters in the genre's symbolic economy. In traditional digital RPGs, players journey through maps to complete quests, encountering hostile NPCs who serve as props or contribute to the player's progression. But in *Undertale*, rather than monsters being obstacles to overcome, it is the player who intrudes on the Underground and disrupts the monsters' lives (Elvery 6). The monsters the player encounters are characters with interiority, history, identities, relationships, and dignity—they are not presented as enemies in any ethically neutral sense. Thus, the act of killing them cannot be counted as conventional combat, but something the game consistently frames as a choice that carries moral weight.

This reframing is reinforced by the game's redefinition of its own progression metrics. In most RPGs, EXP stands for "experience points" and LV for "level"—values that simply measure the player's accumulation of combat power. *Undertale* retroactively redefines these abbreviations: EXP stands for "EXecution Points" and LV for "Level of Violence." This renaming recontextualizes every point of progression the player may have earned through combat, retroactively identifying those gains as the direct product of lethal choices. The player who has been "levelling up" in the conventional RPG sense is forced to recognize that they have been building what the game calls, without irony, their "Level of Violence."

Memory, SAVE, and the Problem of Player Accountability

The ACT/MERCY system creates a moment-to-moment ethical structure. But *Undertale*'s most formally distinctive—and philosophically ambitious—contribution to

the question of player accountability operates across time, through its manipulation of the SAVE and LOAD mechanics that players of the genre take entirely for granted.

In virtually every RPG, the SAVE mechanic functions as an ethical safety net. A player who makes a moral error—for example, killing a character they later regret killing—or who chooses a path they wish to reverse, can reload a previous save file and try again. The game’s memory of their mistake is erased; consequences are undone; the player is returned to a state of moral innocence. This capacity to undo is so normalized in the genre that it is rarely recognized as a significant design decision at all. It is simply how games work.

Undertale knows that players know this, and it exploits that knowledge. The game’s SAVE points are narratively foregrounded: rather than being neutral checkpoints, they are diegetically present objects that the protagonist interacts with, receiving messages like “You are filled with determination.” The act of saving is part of the story. More importantly, the game’s memory does not reset cleanly when a player loads a file or even when they restart from the title screen. *Undertale* retains information about a player’s actions across sessions in ways that its NPCs can acknowledge and respond to.

The most dramatic expression of this mechanic involves the character of Sans, a seemingly casual skeleton who becomes the game’s most formidable antagonist in a “genocide” run. Sans’ meta-awareness of the game differentiates him in a way that makes him appear more lifelike. When the player reaches their destination, they are greeted by Sans, who explains the mechanics of the game. The player is judged according to their LV, which triggers a slightly different response depending on how many monsters the player has killed. Throughout many of the judgments, Sans hints that it is likely he and the player have conversed before. At LV fifteen, Sans suggests he has “already tried to steer you in the right direction” in previous playthroughs. The implication is unambiguous: the game remembers, and the game’s characters remember, even when the player believed they had reset.

This persistence of memory is most devastatingly deployed at the conclusion of a genocide run. The player who has killed every monster in the game—who has optimized for maximum “EXecution Points”—is ultimately confronted by the character Chara, who demands the player’s soul. If the player agrees, they receive a “True Reset” that ostensibly wipes the game’s memory. But when a new playthrough begins, Chara addresses that someone—not the character Frisk, not the fictional avatar, but the person at the

keyboard—made the choice to pursue the genocide route. The game refuses to allow the player the comfort of attributing their actions to a fictional character. The choices were always theirs.

Seraphine describes this dynamic through the lens of guilt as an aesthetic force. The genocide route defers—makes absent—most of the rewarding aspects that are present in neutral and pacifist routes (Seraphine 8). The genocide route punishes the player by making the game repetitive and boring. Most of the dialogues disappear, the player spends their time only killing every character they meet, and many nonplayable characters have fled out of fear of what the player might do to them. The world empties. Save points, rather than offering messages of determination, display a count of enemies still left to kill. When every monster in an area has been eliminated, encounters still trigger—but the battle screen simply reads: “But nobody came.” This is one of the most formally controlled moments in the game’s design. The encounter mechanic, stripped of its content, reflects back at the player the consequence of having eliminated everyone who might have occupied that space.

What Seraphine terms a “différance” is in operation here: the game makes felt the absence of what it usually provides. The joy of *Undertale* in a pacifist run—its humour, its warmth, the sense of a populated world with which genuine connection is possible—is something the genocide run can only define negatively. The player hollows out the game. And it is precisely this hollowing, this progressive subtraction of everything that made the world worth inhabiting, that constitutes the moral argument.

The Player as Agent

What unifies the ACT/MERCY system and the SAVE/memory mechanic is a refusal to allow the player to occupy the comfortable position of the uninvolved protagonist. In a conventional RPG, the player character is typically a vessel, a named avatar through whom the player experiences a story, but one whose moral standing is external to the player themselves. The story may present choices, but the choices belong to the character, not the person playing them.

Undertale dismantles this separation. Elvery analyses the game’s naming mechanic—in which the player is asked at the start to “name the fallen human” instead of naming the protagonist—as an early instance of this destabilization. The game clearly attempts to blur the lines between the avatar and the character in its narrative, and

successfully so, considering “59.3% of the respondents, a significant majority, admitted using their own name (or nickname) when prompted at the beginning of the game” (Elvery 13). The name the player believes they have given to their character turns out, late in the game, to belong to a different entity entirely—a revelation that retrospectively reframes every moment the player saw their chosen name on screen as an instance of the game addressing the player directly.

Elvery’s survey data captures the moral effectiveness of this architecture: of those who played the genocide route, fifty-eight percent considered the player responsible for what was happening in the game, while among people who only watched the genocide route online, just fifty-three percent placed responsibility on someone other than the player (Elvery 16). The gap between players and watchers identifies something essential about what *Undertale* achieves. To watch someone else play the genocide route is to observe consequences from a safe distance. To play it is to be the one making the choices—and the game ensures that this distinction is felt.

This is the precise quality that distinguishes *Undertale* from its predecessors in the tradition of moral RPG design. *Ultima IV* asked players to be virtuous by making virtue the condition of completion: playing ethically was, in the end, another optimization strategy. The morality meters of games like *Fable* and *Mass Effect* translated ethical behaviour into visible scores, reducing moral reflection to resource management. *Undertale* does something categorically different: it makes the player feel the weight of their choices through the behaviour of a world that remembers them. As Zagal has argued, the most ethically effective games are those that make the player—rather than merely a player-controlled character—face the moral dilemma directly, ensuring that the stakes feel personal. *Undertale* achieves precisely this, and does so in a way that no game before it had fully realized.

The rhetoric of *Undertale*, to use Bogost’s term, is not a message appended to its gameplay but a property of its mechanics themselves. Every element of the game’s system—the asymmetry of FIGHT and ACT, the NPC memory that persists across resets, the redefining of EXP and LV, the mirror that tells a genocide-route player their own name in first person—is an argument about what it means to be an agent in a world populated by others. The game makes players experience the consequences of violence directly, and then ensures that they cannot pretend they did not choose them.

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